

Stratus expands in Europe

By ROBERT SCHNEIDER

News Staff Writer

NATICK — Stratus Computer Inc., a Natick-based company that shipped its first computer system just last month, has announced a three-year \$40 million export contract with Ing. C. Olivetti & Co. of Italy.

The contract gives Olivetti the right to market the Stratus-32 Continuing Process System in France, Italy, Spain, South Africa and South America.

Also, Olivetti plans to integrate the Stratus-32 into their own application systems. This OEM arrangement allows Olivetti to distribute worldwide its own systems, with a Stratus computer at the core of the system.

The contract with Olivetti stipulates that Olivetti must meet minimum volume requirements of \$40 million in order to retain marketing rights.

In addition, Olivetti will market the Stratus system in the United Kingdom, West Germany and Benelux. But Stratus retains the right to open an international sales office in these countries upon

90-days notice to Olivetti, according to Peter Kastner, Stratus communications director.

Kastner said Stratus plans to open its first international office in one of these countries by January of 1983.

Stratus Computer, founded about two-years ago, unveiled its first product, the Stratus-32 Continuous Processing System, early in November, 1981.

Stratus was founded with \$6.7 million in financing from several from venture capital groups, including Olivetti, General Electric, Bank of America, Institutional Venture Partners, and others.

The contract "will help us greatly in our overall corporate growth," Kastner said.

The company's goal is to ship 30 systems this year, sold at \$150,000-\$300,000 each.

Kastner said despite the size of the Olivetti contract, Stratus will company will stick to its current business plan. The company will wait until the third or fourth quarter before it considers whether is should revise its goals upward.

To date, the company has ship-

ped systems to four firms, including the West Lynn Creamery and Thom McAn Shoe Co., according to Kastner.

Shipments to Olivetti are scheduled to begin in April.

"Most of the sales volume will be in the later years of the contract," he said. "First of all, there is no way we could build \$40 million worth of computers this year. And secondly, it will take Olivetti a while to integrate the system into their product line."

The Stratus-32 system is a "fail safe" system, designed to eliminate costly computer downtime. Dual components are constantly working in lock-step with one another, so even if several different components are down, the system continues to operate.

It is a 32-bit super mini computer.

These arrangements with Olivetti represent a major step in the company's plans to market Stratus computers on international markets, according John Morgridge, Stratus marketing vice-president.